

AI Readiness Checklist

for Small & Mid-Sized Businesses

7 dimensions to evaluate before your first AI project

Leadership & Strategy

- Do you have executive buy-in for AI initiatives?
- Is there a clear vision for how AI will create business value?
- Do you have allocated budget for AI projects?

People & Culture

- Are your teams open to learning new AI-powered tools?
- Do you have or can you recruit AI-skilled talent?
- Is there change management support in place?
- Are roles and responsibilities for AI oversight defined?

Data & Infrastructure

- Can you access and consolidate data needed for AI?
- Is your IT infrastructure capable of supporting AI tools?
- Do you have data quality and governance processes?

Processes & Workflows

- Have you identified specific processes that AI could improve?
- Are your current processes documented and standardized?
- Can you measure success with clear KPIs?

Governance & Risk

- Do you have a framework for AI decision-making oversight?

- Are AI risks identified and mitigation plans in place?
- Is accountability assigned for AI system performance?

Security & Compliance

- Do your security practices meet data protection standards?
- Are you aware of relevant regulatory requirements (GDPR, etc.)?
- Can you audit AI system decisions when needed?

Vendor & Tool Ecosystem

- Have you evaluated available AI vendors and tools?
- Do vendors offer adequate support and training?
- Are you comfortable with vendor pricing and lock-in terms?

Using This Checklist

Review each dimension and check off items where you have confidence. Areas with fewer checkmarks represent opportunities for improvement before your first AI project. This isn't a pass/fail assessment—it's a baseline to guide your preparation.

Scoring Guide

- 5-7 checkmarks per dimension: You're ready to pilot an AI project
- 3-4 checkmarks per dimension: Address key gaps before scaling AI
- 1-2 checkmarks per dimension: Invest in foundational work first

Next Steps

Want a deeper assessment? Book a free 30-minute consultation at freshcoastai.com/contact.html